

Environmental Scan: The Canadian Hospitality Industry (Hotels and Restaurants)

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1. Introduction and Key Findings

This scan treats Canadian hospitality as two segments, hotels and restaurants. They share a customer but experience the same external forces very differently. The scan combines structured sources (CoStar benchmarks, Statistics Canada frontier counts and company filings) with unstructured ones (consumer surveys, trade press and TikTok commentary). This is the searching mode of scanning described by Daft and Weick (1984). Four strategy frameworks organize the analysis: PESTEL for the macro environment, Porter's Five Forces for industry structure, Porter's generic strategies for competitor positioning, and a TOWS matrix that turns the findings into recommendations.

Key findings. (1) Hotels are growing through higher room rates while restaurants are losing margin. (2) The 2025 domestic travel windfall is fading as Canadians return to the United States. (3) Restaurant rivalry has become a price war led by the largest chains, leaving mid-market operators stuck in the middle. (4) Customers are changing what they order, and how often, faster than most menus are changing.

2. Macro Environment: PESTEL Analysis

Table 1 separates political and legal factors because they act through different channels. Political factors shift demand through trade tension and travel incentives. Legal factors shift costs and conduct through wage, labour, pricing and rental rules.

Table 1. PESTEL analysis, 2025 to 2026, and net effect by segment

Factor	Evidence	Hotels	Restaurants
Economic	Real foodservice sales are forecast to grow 1.5% in 2026, yet 64% of operators report lower profits and 41% are losing money or breaking even (Toneguzzi, 2026). Food prices are forecast to rise 4% to 6%, and beef sits 23% above its five-year average (Dalhousie University, 2025). Hotel ADR rose 6.7% in August, the eighth straight monthly gain, while occupancy was flat (CoStar, 2026b).	Positive, rate-led	Negative: margin squeeze
Political	Canadian trips to the U.S. fell for 15 straight months to March 2026, then rose 5.0% in June and about 10% in July, though they remain 27% to 29% below 2024 levels (Statistics Canada, 2026a, 2026b; Travelweek, 2026). U.S. visits to Canada rose 6.1% in June. Ottawa's Canada Strong Pass (June 19 to September 7, 2026) offered free national park entry and discounts on rail and park accommodation to keep Canadians travelling at home (Parks Canada, n.d.).	Positive but fading	Mildly positive in tourist areas
Legal	The low-wage TFW cap is 10%, rising to 15% for rural employers only in provinces that opt in (McCarthy Tétrault, 2026). Ontario's minimum wage rose to \$17.95 on October 1, 2026 (Hicks Morley, 2026). Bill C-59 bans drip pricing, so resort fees, service fees and other mandatory charges must appear in the advertised price (Davies, 2024). B.C. and Vancouver require short-term rental registration and licences (The Canadian Press, 2025).	Mixed: labour costs up; fee transparency; rental rules limit substitutes	Negative: labour is the largest controllable cost
Social	80% of Canadians are eating out less because of the cost of living, up from 75% a year earlier (Restaurants Canada, 2026c). 93% are annoyed by tip prompts and 40% avoid businesses where tipping is expected (Toronto Life, 2026). People taking GLP-1 medication order smaller portions and more protein (National Restaurant Association, 2026).	Neutral	Negative for traffic and cheque size
Technological	26% of U.S. operators use AI tools but only 6% use them for ordering (Restaurant Dive, 2026). Most AI value so far sits back-of-house, in forecasting and scheduling.	Positive (pricing, distribution)	Positive if applied back-of-house
Environmental	By July 9, Canada had recorded 3,137 fires and 1.4 million hectares burned. In August, intense fires in the Fraser Canyon and Okanagan left more than 10,000 people under evacuation orders (Public Safety Canada, 2026a, 2026b).	Negative regionally	Negative regionally

Reading the evidence critically. Forecasts are volatile. Within six months, Restaurants Canada moved its 2026 outlook from a 1.1% real decline (Restaurants Canada, 2026a) to 1.5% growth. The Agri-Food Analytics Lab cut its projected net restaurant closures from about 4,000 to between 1,500 and 2,500 (Charlebois, 2026). Both sources also lobby for policy relief, so operators should weight

their own transaction data above them. The labour shortage is also narrower than it sounds. Temporary foreign workers make up only about 3% of the restaurant workforce (Restaurants Canada, 2026b), and the industry added roughly 50,000 young workers in the first half of 2026 (Toneguzzi, 2026). Both facts point to regional and skills gaps rather than a national shortage. On balance, hotels have demand tailwinds while restaurants face cost headwinds.

3. Industry Structure: Porter's Five Forces

Table 2 rates each force separately for hotels and restaurants, because the same force can differ sharply between the two segments.

Table 2. Five Forces assessment by segment (author analysis of sources cited)

Force	Hotels	Restaurants	Evidence and implication
Rivalry	Moderate	High	On January 13, 2026, McDonald's cut McValue meals to \$5 and froze them and its \$1 small coffee for a year (The Canadian Press, 2026). Burger King and Wendy's responded with their own value bundles and discounts (Retail Insider, 2026a). Hotel rivalry is softer because supply will grow only 1.2% in 2026 (Lodging Econometrics, 2026). Implication: restaurants compete on price, hotels on rate and loyalty.
Threat of new entrants	Low to moderate	Moderate	Well-funded brands keep entering: Chick-fil-A is moving into B.C., and Recipe holds exclusive rights to expand Olive Garden (Retail Insider, 2025a, 2025c). High construction costs slow hotel entry. Implication: new entrants are scale players, not independents.
Threat of substitutes	Moderate	High	Home cooking competes for every restaurant visit. Short-term rentals substitute for hotels, but registration and licensing rules cap their growth in key markets (The Canadian Press, 2025). Implication: restaurants must justify the occasion, not just the meal.
Buyer power	Moderate	High	80% of consumers are cutting back. Customers avoid businesses where tipping is expected and publicize poor value on social media (Toronto Life, 2026; Daily Dot, 2026). Bill C-59 makes all-in prices easy to compare. Implication: perceived value now decides traffic.
Supplier power	Moderate	High	Beef and chicken prices are rising (Dalhousie University, 2025), rural labour is scarce, and delivery platforms take roughly 15% to 30% per order (DineOpen, 2026). Implication: owned channels and labour productivity are the main levers.

Strategic implication. The structure explains the profit gap. Restaurants face four high-intensity forces, while hotels benefit from constrained supply and regulated substitutes. Operators cannot change industry structure, but they can weaken individual forces. Loyalty programs reduce buyer power, owned digital ordering reduces the platforms' channel power, and differentiated menus reduce the threat of substitutes. Section 6 builds on these levers.

4. Competitive Landscape and Generic Strategies

4.1 Ten leading competitors

Table 3. Ten leading competitors, five per segment, classified by generic strategy

Competitor	Generic strategy	Strengths	Weaknesses	Recent strategic moves
1. McDonald's Canada	Cost leadership	About 1,500 restaurants; buying volume and long supplier relationships fund price cuts	Customers routinely complain about the prices of flagship items	\$5 McValue meals and \$1 small coffee frozen for a year (January 2026)
2. Tim Hortons (RBI)	Cost leadership (convenience)	Most entrenched national brand; about 40% of RBI operating profit	Canadian same-store sales +0.1% in Q2 2026, down from +3.6% a year earlier	New marketing calendar built on cold beverages and partnerships
3. Recipe Unlimited	Broad differentiation (multi-brand)	Canada's largest full-service operator; 1,200+ restaurants; Scene+ partner (15 million members)	Concentrated in mid-market full-service dining, the most exposed segment	Bought Canada's eight Olive Garden restaurants, with exclusive national expansion rights (2025)
4. MTY Food Group	Broad, multi-brand franchising	35% of locations in Canada; digital is 21% of system sales	Canadian same-store sales -1.8% as traffic falls	Closing 68 underperforming corporate stores
5. Chick-fil-A	Differentiation focus (service)	Owner-operator model; record eight Canadian openings in 2025	Each restaurant needs 80 to 120 staff	First B.C. restaurant expected late 2027 or early 2028; new Calgary location (September 2026)

Competitor	Generic strategy	Strengths	Weaknesses	Recent strategic moves
6. Marriott International	Broad differentiation, asset-light	300+ Canadian hotels; Bonvoy loyalty program	Growth depends on owners financing new builds	About 11 Canadian openings in 2026; first Canadian City Express (midscale) in Port Hope
7. Hilton	Differentiation (select-service)	Nearly 215 Canadian hotels by end of 2026; Honors loyalty program	No co-branded Hilton credit card in Canada	Eight 2026 openings, including Tru, Spark and Homewood Suites
8. IHG Hotels & Resorts	Focus (midscale, extended stay)	200+ Canadian hotels; large global loyalty base	Growth concentrated in smaller secondary markets	Six 2026 openings in Ontario towns; pipeline of nearly 40 hotels
9. Choice Hotels	Cost focus (conversion-led)	About 350 Canadian hotels; Q1 2026 RevPAR +5.2%	Midscale and economy guests are the most price-sensitive	Direct franchising after buying out its Canadian partner; pipeline rooms +55%
10. Accor (Fairmont)	Differentiation focus (heritage luxury)	Iconic assets such as the Royal York and Château Frontenac	Historic buildings need heavy capital spending	20% of Fairmont hotels under renovation; Jasper lodge relaunched June 2026

Sources by row: (1) *The Canadian Press* (2026); (2) *Restaurant Brands International* (2026); (3) *Retail Insider* (2025b, 2025c), *Charlebois* (2026); (4) *MTY Food Group* (2026); (5) *Retail Insider* (2025a, 2026b); (6) *Rewards Canada* (2026a), *The Bulkhead Seat* (2026); (7) *Rewards Canada* (2026b); (8) *TOPHOTELNEWS* (2026a); (9) *Choice Hotels International* (2026); (10) *TOPHOTELNEWS* (2026b).

4.2 Generic strategy positioning

Porter's framework classifies firms by their source of advantage (lower cost or differentiation) and their competitive scope (broad or narrow). Table 4 maps the ten competitors onto that grid.

Table 4. Generic strategy map of the ten competitors

Scope	Lower-cost advantage	Differentiation advantage
Broad target	Cost leadership: McDonald's, Tim Hortons, MTY (multi-brand scale). They win on price and convenience, and the price war is their contest.	Differentiation: Marriott, Hilton, Recipe. They win through loyalty programs, brand portfolios and asset-light growth.
Narrow target	Cost focus: Choice Hotels, IHG (midscale and extended stay). They serve value-seeking travellers in secondary markets through conversions.	Differentiation focus: Chick-fil-A (service), Fairmont (heritage luxury). They earn pricing power but are limited by labour and capital.
Stuck in the middle	Most at risk: mid-priced casual dining chains and independents. They have neither the cost base to match \$5 meals nor a clear reason to pay more. Recipe's mid-market banners and MTY's weaker brands sit closest to this zone.	

Strategic interpretation. The value war is a cost-leadership contest that only the largest chains can afford. McDonald's is openly trading margin for traffic, and that squeezes the mid-market. Groups without a cost advantage are either pruning (MTY is closing stores) or buying proven brands (Recipe's Olive Garden deal) rather than building new ones. In lodging, every major company is growing asset-light through franchising and conversions. Marriott's launch of the midscale City Express brand shows the leaders reaching down-market rather than leaving it to cost-focused rivals. Chick-fil-A and Fairmont show the alternative: differentiation that earns pricing power. Mid-market operators must commit to one side of the grid.

What customers are saying. McDonald's Canada admits customers routinely complain about flagship prices (*The Canadian Press*, 2026). In September 2026, a TikTok rant about a \$16 fast-food meal resurfaced with 2.2 million likes, and Canadian commenters said prices are even higher here (*Daily Dot*, 2026). Customers now compare value publicly and in real time.

5. Market Changes, Trends and Opportunities

- **Pricing power depends on the event calendar.** Moving the Canadian Grand Prix to May lifted Montreal ADR 26.7% (*Hotelier Magazine*, 2026). In June, World Cup matches raised Toronto RevPAR 10.4%. In Vancouver, ADR jumped 21.3% but occupancy fell 15.8%, and national occupancy posted its first decline of 2026 (*CoStar*, 2026a). Event pricing displaced regular travellers instead of adding to them.
- **The domestic windfall is fading.** Canadians are resuming U.S. trips, and destinations such as New York City are courting them with 30% discounts (*Global News*, 2026). Growth is shifting to American and overseas visitors. Arrivals from the 15 overseas countries that played World Cup matches in Canada rose 28.6% in June (*Statistics Canada*, 2026b).
- **Value, smaller portions and less alcohol.** Customers eat out less often and order less when they do. Operators that emphasize protein, quality, smaller portions and experience are expected

to adapt better than volume-led ones (Charlebois, 2026). Lower drink sales hurt disproportionately, because alcohol carries the highest margins.

- **Emerging opportunities.** Four stand out: event packages that capture peak demand without displacing regular business; American and overseas visitors; smaller-portion, protein-forward and low-alcohol menus; and owned digital ordering that recovers the margin lost to delivery commissions.

6. Strategic Recommendations: TOWS Matrix

The TOWS matrix pairs the industry's internal strengths and weaknesses with the external opportunities and threats identified above. Each quadrant produces a different type of strategy: SO uses strengths to capture opportunities, WO uses opportunities to fix weaknesses, ST uses strengths to blunt threats, and WT minimizes weaknesses in order to survive threats. Every recommendation below is tied to one quadrant, a KPI and a deadline.

Table 5. TOWS matrix: recommendations, KPIs and timing

	Strengths (S) S1 Constrained hotel supply and rate power S2 Loyalty scale and guest data at chains S3 Canadian brand affinity	Weaknesses (W) W1 Thin restaurant margins W2 Heavy dependence on scarce labour W3 Reliance on delivery platforms; data not integrated
Opportunities (O) O1 Event demand and U.S./overseas visitors O2 Smaller-portion, protein-forward, low-alcohol demand O3 AI and owned digital channels	SO: Grow 1. Build an external-signals data mart. Combine event calendars, CoStar competitive-set data, Statistics Canada travel counts and air-quality forecasts with POS and property data. Set minimum-stay and group rules for peak weeks so event pricing does not displace regular demand (S1, S2, O1). KPI: RevPAR index vs. competitive set. By: summer 2027. 2. Court growing markets. Bundle rooms, dining and experiences for domestic guests, and shift marketing spend to U.S. and overseas origins (S2, S3, O1). KPI: direct-booking share; repeat stays by origin. By: immediately.	WO: Fix 3. Reclaim customers from delivery platforms. Move repeat buyers to owned ordering and loyalty programs. This reduces the platforms' channel power and gives the operator the customer data (W3, O3). KPI: owned share of digital orders; commission cost per order. By: within 6 months. 4. Put AI behind the counter first. Use forecasting-driven scheduling and prep before voice ordering. Rural operators should press their provinces to opt in to the 15% TFW cap and cross-train staff (W2, O3). KPI: labour hours per transaction; food waste. By: 6 to 12 months.
Threats (T) T1 Value war and price-sensitive buyers T2 Canadians returning to U.S. travel T3 Wildfires and smoke T4 Food and labour inflation	ST: Defend 5. Chains: win the value war visibly. Match competitors on a clear entry-price tier funded by scale (S2), and use loyalty offers to keep Canadians travelling at home despite U.S. discounts (T1, T2). KPI: transaction count; repeat-visit rate. By: next menu cycle. 6. Write a wildfire and smoke playbook. Offer flexible cancellation, send guests air-quality alerts, show visible air filtration, and shift promotions to unaffected regions (S1, T3). KPI: cancellation rate during smoke events. By: before the 2027 fire season.	WT: Survive 7. Independents and mid-market chains: escape the middle. Differentiate on quality, smaller protein-forward portions and experience instead of matching \$5 meals. Drop counter tip prompts and show all-in prices, as Bill C-59 requires. Use menu engineering to cut low-margin items (W1, T1, T4). KPI: contribution margin per item; average cheque; tip-prompt complaints. By: next menu cycle.

Sequencing. Priorities differ by segment. Hotels should lead with SO strategies 1 and 2; restaurants with WO and WT strategies 3, 4 and 7, because their weaknesses are the binding constraint. All depend on one business intelligence capability: combining external signals with the operator's own transaction data.

7. Conclusion

In 2026, Canadian hospitality is growing on paper but shrinking at the margin. Hotels are enjoying rate-led gains protected by slow supply growth, though the domestic windfall behind them is fading. Restaurants face four high-intensity forces: a price war, rising input costs, customers who order less, and powerful channel suppliers. The winners in 2027 will be operators that commit to one generic strategy rather than drifting into the middle, integrate external signals with their own data, and plan for both cross-border competition and a longer fire season.

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